

Spiritual Reasons and Expert Authority

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Teacher: Dr. Donald Chinonso Ude

Myla White
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1. Introduction

In 2023, British Columbia observed the worst wildfire season in the province's history, with over 2.8 million hectares (or approximately 4.2 per cent of the province's forested land) burned (BC Wildfire Service 2026). Increased wildfire severity over the past decade is attributed to a number of factors, from mountain pine beetle infestations, rising average temperatures amidst the climate crisis, and sweeping environmental changes at the hands of both industry and public development. The destruction of wildfires is not isolated to British Columbia, as recent years have also seen increased activity from California to the Australian bush.

In the wake of escalating environmental disaster, human displacement, and rising firefighting and restoration costs, states most impacted by the onset of wildfires have turned to alternative solutions in an attempt to mitigate their impacts. One particular avenue has involved the reintroduction of fire burning practices into state fire management initiatives. While Indigenous populations across the Pacific Northwest and beyond have practiced prescribed and cultural burning since time immemorial, cultural burning was banned by the province of British Columbia in the Bush Fire Act of 1874 (BC Wildfire Service 2022). Cultural and prescribed burning practices contain a multitude of environmental benefits, from removing spark-prone plants and debris from the forest floor, to pest management and disease eradication, to general forest management. As part of both increased reconciliatory efforts within Canada — including the enshrining of the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples into Canadian law in 2021 — and the pursuit of more thorough wildfire management initiatives, British Columbia reintroduced prescribed burns as a fire management tool in the province.

Beyond the ecological knowledge contained in fire burning, it is important to note the spiritual aspect of the practice. Indigenous Fire Keepers tend to fire in a manner sacred to the religious practices of their culture, and cultural burning plays an important role in both ceremony and communal protection (Christianson et al. 2024). As such, cultural and prescribed burns cannot be reduced down to simply the application of environmental knowledge — they are inherently spiritual, and the integration of these spiritual practices into resource management policy has had a resounding impact on wildfire mitigation within the province.

Against the backdrop of the ongoing debate surrounding the level of acceptance of religious reasoning into secular politics, the cases of more localized spiritualities are often

overlooked. While it intuitively seems unacceptable to allow for reasons based in institutional religions to carry any authority in policy discussions regarding same-sex marriage, or biomedical policies such as abortion access or medical assistance in dying, there may be greater acceptability in integrating reasons based in localized spiritualities into public policy, such as in the example of integrating Indigenous spirituality into matters regarding natural resource management. There is a straightforward justice analysis to be made here. The reintegration of localized cultural practices and spiritualities is just one reconciliatory measure to be undertaken by colonial states in the wake of their historic, and ongoing, colonization of Indigenous peoples. However, it seems to me to be too reductive of a move to suggest that the integration of spiritual reasoning into political discourse is solely a matter of justice. There are truths contained within localized spiritual reasons, which can provide unique insights into the politics of a region. Furthermore, there is an epistemic difference in the knowledge contained in reasons based in institutional religions and those found in localized spiritualities. Considering spiritual reasoning in politics solely on the axis of justice minimizes the rigour and weight of the truths they contain.

In what follows, I will respond to a model of religious reasoning and integration presented by Stefan Rummens. I argue that localized spiritualities are unique sources of authority on regional knowledge and values grounded in location. To develop this argument, I will first provide an overview of Rummens's position, situated within the inclusion and exclusion debate regarding the admittance of religious reasons into liberal democracies. Then, I will introduce my concept of *localized spiritual reasons* as good-faith, legitimate reasons to be entered into the public sphere. Specifically, I argue that local spiritual reasons differ from those of institutional religions in that the knowledge they contain is both developed on and intimately intertwined with the region where political discussions occur — giving them a unique kind of authority grounded in expertise. Lastly, I consider a number of outstanding concerns related to this formulation.

2. Acceptability of Religious Reasons

Stefan Rummens (building atop a conception of secular reasons provided by Robert Audi (2000, 89)) defines religious reasons as those “characterized by the fact that their justificatory force is based on some kind of *religious source of authority* such as divine command, religious texts or religious institutions” (Rummens 2010, 387). I would like to adopt this definition for the

purposes of this paper, and extend it to clarify that religion-based justifications for political positions can also be direct or indirect. Direct religious reasons contain a clear link between themselves and the political policy they support. Consider the aforementioned rejection of same-sex marriage based specifically on Leviticus 18:22, which characterizes same-sex intercourse as an “abomination”, or on Genesis 1:27, in which Jesus refers to marriage as the union between a male and a female (*Wikipedia* 2026, “The Bible and homosexuality”). The religious source of authority in these cases is straightforward and easily determined. As such, their entrance into the political discourse can be clearly identified and evaluated.

In my view, the more common case is for religious reasons to indirectly provide justification for political policies. Consider, for instance, the support for judicial policies grounded in retributive justice for certain crimes, such as mandatory minimum sentences or capital punishment. The sort of person who supports these policies may possess the values of proportionality or desert. However, the sorts of values which justify retributive policies can also be found within religions, including Catholic perspectives of retribution as a form of remediation for wrongdoing or Islamic teachings on recompense. Here, it is difficult to determine whether the supporters of these policies arrived on the adoption of said values through logical inquiry and communal reflection, or through the cultural diluting (but still passing-on) of the religious values found at the inception of a given society. More generally, these sorts of justifications are all the more difficult to trace back to their root and determine whether they arise solely through rational, naturalistic, and humanist secular reasons or from deeply culturally embedded religious perspectives. In this way, the classification between indirect religious reasons and secular reasons is easily blurred.

To what extent the admission of religious reasons can be admitted into public deliberation regarding policies in secular, liberal states (or, the extent to which they are allowed into the public sphere) is the subject of ongoing debate, which can be separated into inclusionist and exclusionist accounts (Rummens 2010). The exclusionist argument, as characterized by Rawls, states that in a liberal democracy citizens should base their arguments on public reason — founded in a shared, secular knowledge base. This perspective is intertwined with the liberal requirement for a political framework which produces rationally acceptable outcomes in order to generate political legitimacy within governance. More specifically, citizens participating in the deliberative aspect of democracy owe both themselves and each other “good reasons” for the

principles and policies they support — reasons which can be conceivably engaged with and accepted by all people regardless of their religion (Habermas 2006, 4–5). Rawls presents a *translation proviso* which states that in order to be accepted into the public sphere, any religious reasons utilized in the private sphere must first be translated into a parallel, secular argument for the same position. His concern regarding the inclusion of religious reasons into public discourse involves preventing the coercion of nonreligious citizens, who may be subjected to following religious values they do not align with if they are enshrined into law (Rawls 1993, 1997).

The inclusionist argument, presented by Habermas, states that religious reasoning should be included in the public sphere as part of the multicultural, liberal ethos. According to Habermas, there is good in cultural and religious diversity, as well as the possibility that religious perspectives could contain moral truths or other insights conducive to public debate. Disallowing the admittance of religious reasons runs the risk of missing out on the important truths they may contain, as well as demanding self-censorship of religious communities and encumbering religious citizens with potentially impossible demands for democratic participation (Habermas 2006, 7–8). Habermas modifies Rawls’ translation proviso such that religious reasons only need to be translated once they have entered the formal political sphere, such as in parliament. Otherwise, in the informal public sphere, citizens should maintain the right to argue for political standpoints using religious reasons (Habermas 2006).

The keen reader may, at this point, note that the phrase “religious reasons” is often utilized in a sweeping, potentially imprecise manner. It may be the case (and certainly, this is what I will come to argue) that particular forms, sources, or contents of religious reasons lead to conflicting intuitions regarding their acceptability that deserves further scrutiny. Previously, I attempted to clarify the variations in justificatory dimensions of religious reasons. Rummens elaborates on the different kinds, or variations in content, of religious arguments.

In his analysis, Rummens introduces three categories of religious arguments: autonomy, identity, and authority arguments. Autonomy arguments are those concerning the autonomy of all citizens, and contribute to the more general debate within liberalism regarding human autonomy as a core value. Identity arguments support claims that certain practices express foundational values and identity characteristics of individual citizens, which should be accommodated within the liberal framework. A common example of these sorts of cases is the justification for wearing religious symbols in public spaces, such as students being allowed to wear certain headwear at

school, or public servants being allowed to don religious artifacts at work. Lastly, authority arguments classify religious sources as forms of authority over a given topic. Our example of the divine authority against same-sex marriage is an obvious case of this sort of argument (Rummens 2010, 387–389).

It is important to note that Rummens' analysis is intimately intertwined with the political framework of a deliberative democracy, which he advocates for¹. In a liberal deliberative democracy, the generation of political legitimacy lies within the practice of sensible deliberation between citizens, with the aim of arriving at a reasonable consensus (Rummens 2010, 390). This can be contrasted with the Rawlsian concept of reasonable acceptability, in which political legitimacy is found when the use of political power (or choices of principles of justice) is done in a way that all citizens would deem reasonable, regardless of their position in society (Rawls 1993, 137). Against this framework of a discursive democracy, Rummens determines autonomy and identity arguments to be acceptable kinds of religious reasons to enter into the public sphere. However, authority arguments are deemed inadmissible. Authority arguments necessarily end discussion, as the structure of their argument is that a certain political aim or policy should be accepted solely based on the say-so of some religious authority. Under the deliberative model, discussion is meant to be open-ended with the potential for participants to convince one another of their perspectives. Appealing to religious reasoning as authority means that the speaker has already pre-determined the results, and there is no political legitimacy to derive from the process (Rummens 2010, 393–394).

It is of my opinion that Rummens' project is greatly important in drawing attention not just to the acceptability of religious reasons generally, but the acceptability of certain classes of religious reasons particularly. However, much of the examples within this debate focus on reasons grounded in global, institutional religions such as Islam, Christianity, or Judaism. While

¹ For the purposes of this paper, I will also be adopting the model of a deliberative democracy. My intention is to maintain focus on the dissection of the religious reasons themselves, rather than the framework they operate within. It must be noted that a given political framework can have a great impact on the permissibility of certain reasons — if we were operating under the assumption of a theocracy, the discussion would resolve quickly.

However, I am hesitant to accept that any derivation of liberalism must be the framework within which more localized spiritualities can be accepted, as it is under the name of liberalism that much of the subjugation regarding these sorts of reasons was committed in the first place. It would be intellectually malicious to suggest that the adoption of Indigenous spiritual reasons into the public sphere must occur under the framework which itself is the reason for their exclusion, as is certainly the case in Canada. The framework which best allows for the integration of these sorts of reasons may lie outside of liberalism entirely, but this is a subject worthy of independent discussion.

the pivot to looking at specific types of *reasons* has found to be fertile ground for investigation, the focus on one category of *religions* has resulted in the omission of equally vibrant cases. These cases often lead to opposing intuitions than those derived from the examples discussed prior. Namely, I argue that there are cases of localized spiritual reasons that are both authoritative in nature, and admissible into the public sphere, contrary to Rummens' categorization. In the following section, I will outline the unique characteristics found in these localized spiritual reasons which result in differing intuitions.

3. Localized Spiritualities

In 2003, Correctional Service Canada (CSC) introduced an Indigenous Continuum of Care model in an effort to combat the over-incarceration of Indigenous populations in Canadian prisons. The Indigenous Continuum of Care model aimed to provide a continuum of support and spiritual and cultural services, from intake to release, with a critical role being played by First Nations, Métis, and Inuit Elders and Spiritual Advisors who would assist through counselling, ceremony, and re-connection with families and communities (“Correctional Programming for Indigenous Offenders” 2019). Advocates for the right of Indigenous inmates to exercise their spirituality, and for CSC to implement more culturally appropriate interventions, highlighted in part the difference in philosophy between the Canadian justice system and Indigenous spirituality². This difference is summarized in a policy proposal for integrating Indigenous spirituality into Canadian correctional approaches by Evelyn Zellerer, who states that in Native society,

“[c]riminal activity is seen as a collective responsibility where atonement and restoration of harmony were the desired goals. Once this was accomplished, the matter was forgotten. There were no such notions as adversarial justice or guilt.

² It must be emphasized that Indigeneity is not a monolith, and the Canadian government alone recognizes over 640 First Nations, Métis, and Inuit communities, each with their own unique languages, cultural practices, and spiritualities (“First Nations” 2025). The aim with this example is not to reduce, stereotype, or romanticize some homogenous concept of “Indigenous spirituality”. However, as Zellerer writes, there are some major ethical and spiritual principles shared by Indigenous peoples, which can be helpful for the purposes of contrasting against deeply-rooted Western principles and perspectives (1992, 253–255).

This contrasts with the dominant White justice system which, put very simply, seeks to punish offenders and protect society. Rather than atonement to the parties injured and a restoration of harmony, the end result is often the incarceration of offenders.” (Zellerer 1992, 255)

Zellerer points to the values which underlie colonial prison systems as focusing on “changing individual offenders into law abiding citizens of mainstream society,” whereas Indigenous philosophy focuses on practices of acknowledgement and reparation or compensation, with the aim of restoring harmony to a community (1992, 255). This approach is deeply intertwined with the spirituality of a given culture, and as such, cannot be separated. It is also important to note that the changes, as recommended, differ from the presence or services provided by a prison chaplain. Proposed corrections reforms, driven by reasons from Indigenous spirituality, involve not just the addition of spiritually relevant services, but the modification of the carceral framework and policy itself.³

The two major policy examples in this paper, which I will label *Fire Burning* and *Corrections*, both entail arguments driven by certain religious reasons. However, these reasons differ from the sorts of reasons — those found in institutional religions — discussed in related literature. These reasons derive from what I will term *localized spiritualities*. Localized spiritualities are those developed on, and grounded within, the land that said spirituality is practiced on. While, up to this point, I have been referring to reasons found in Indigenous spiritualities, it is not my intent to constrain the argument of this paper to solely this category. Localized spiritualities, as I have defined them, are often the sort practiced by Indigenous peoples — and are unquestionably worthy of prioritization and care in the discussion due to the colonial dimension of their subjugation. Yet my aim for this argument is to encompass those localized spiritualities developed by non-Native peoples as well. The emphasis on Indigenous spirituality and liberal policy is also greatly informed by the context of my familiarity (where many of my driving intuitions are derived from) as a lifelong citizen of Canada. Intuitions will most certainly differ in other contexts.

³ While CSC has adopted a continuum of care model and made other efforts to provide culturally appropriate corrections, despite a decrease in the *total* incarcerated population in Canada, there has been an increase in the *percentage* of Indigenous incarceration. This increase is attributed to a multitude of factors, from woefully inadequate societal supports outside of the prison system, to claims that the initiatives undertaken by the CSC do not align with more precise recommendations put forth by organizations and community groups most embedded in domain research. For a thorough, contemporary overview of Canadian Indigenous Corrections’ shortcomings and potential reforms, see Correctional Investigator of Canada Ivan Zinger’s report “Ten Years since Spirit Matters” (Zinger 2023).

Fire Burning illustrates the use of direct spiritual reasons in the public sphere. Various cultural practices centred around fire stewardship can be directly cited as justification for prescribed burns as both a spiritual practice and a land management tool. *Corrections* is an example of indirect spiritual reasons in policy proposals — namely, culturally-relevant corrections are advised by overarching Indigenous ethical values of “non-interference, non-competitiveness, emotional restraint and sharing” which are themselves inseparable from localized spiritual perspectives (Zellerer 1992, 254). Both of these examples fit into Rummens’ category of authority arguments, but they intuitively seem permissible, and even advantageous, in their admittance into the public sphere. The unique characteristic that these reasons have in common, which differ from comparable cases justified by institutional religious reasons, is that *the content of the reasons is developed on, and intimately tied to, the location on which the political discourse is occurring*. This grounding in locale gives rise to a unique form of authority based in expertise.

It is worth noting that the inquiry into a reason’s authority is of a metaphysical nature regarding the reasons themselves, rather than the content of the reason. To clarify, when we say that the chemist’s words hold some authority in a policy discussion surrounding vaccines, we designate this status to *her* and *her reasons*, rather than the *content* of her reasons. This is not to say that the content of her reasons does not contain some significance (intertwined perhaps with their logic or proximity to truth), but this differs from the authority attached to their grounding rationale and their source. As such, before turning to the discussion on authority, I will first address the issue of legitimacy regarding the content contained in localized spiritual reasons, derived from their proximate grounding. While the question of authority asks why a reason should carry greater weight in a discussion in comparison to other reasons, the question of legitimacy inquires into the rationale behind the content of a reason, and whether it is sensible for a given reason to be considered in a discussion in the first place (à la Rawls’ reasonable acceptability). My aim in taking this slight diversion is to show that even prior to considering the metaphysical notion of authority with regards to localized spiritual reasons, the content of the reasons themselves has just as much potential for being good-faith, reasonable, containers of “truth” as comparable secular reasons already accepted into policy discourse.

In keeping with the trend thus far, the case involving direct spiritual reasons is the most straightforward. Examples of these reasons are most often found within the domains of land

management, sustainability, water policy, and climate action — such as the preservation of certain species in the Don Pu Ta Sacred Area of Thailand, or the implementation of food sovereignty policies in Peru based on Quechua spiritual principles. To take a Rawlsian approach, the content of these reasons can be translated and empirically verified, as often occurs in the domain of environmental policy. In this way, direct spiritual reasons can legitimately be entered into the public sphere as they are capable of containing the same rigour, virtue, and rationale as those found in secular, good-faith reasons. Now, I am not suggesting that the benefit of these sorts of reasons is that the knowledge they contain can be extracted, stripped of their context and essence, and injected into secular politics. The content itself is inherently spiritual. But evidently, and ultimately, the legitimacy of that content is capable of being investigated from a number of perspectives and approaches.

To illustrate the legitimacy regarding indirect spiritual reasons, I will begin with a parallel example centred around the culture of honour hypothesis. Cultures with hyper-sensitivity to perceived slights, and which maintain violence as an appropriate response to affronts to personal honour — such as public displays of disrespect, or teasing either oneself or one's family members — are termed cultures of honour. The culture of honour hypothesis states that the development of these values and practices is tied to a culture's pastoral lifestyle (Nisbett and Cohen 2018). Namely, populations whose lifestyles centre around livestock harbour a reactive cultural phenotype, favoured by two conditions prevalent in pastoral cultures: vulnerability to theft, due to the portability of livestock, and lack of legal recourse, due to the remote nature and sparse population of their environment (Linquist 2016). On the other hand, horticultural populations, who are more sedentary and who rely on their neighbours for cooperative tasks such as harvesting and defence, seem to “favour a value system that emphasizes passivity and tolerance — at least among fellow group members” (Linquist 2016, 216; Goldschmidt 1971). In their work, Nisbett and Cohen focus on the cultural differences between American Northerners and Southerners. Northerners were historically farmers with an observed ‘passive’ psychological phenotype, whereas Southerners were historically pastoralists with a ‘reactive’ psychological phenotype (Nisbett and Cohen 2018; Linquist 2016, 216).

One component of the culture of honour hypothesis is the assumption of a causal link between a socioecological environment and the cultural phenotype. The cultural phenotype exists between a population of individuals and refers to the “body of socially transmitted information

(e.g. norms, social scripts, parenting strategies, religious convictions, technologies, etc.)” shared within their cultural group (Linguist 2016, 215). The socioecological environment refers to “a set of conditions that determine the social and biological costs and benefits associated with certain patterns of behaviour” (215). So, for example, under this hypothesis the vulnerable nature of livestock ranching may contribute to value systems of hyper-reactivity as a form of theft deterrence.

I would also like to note that the historic determination of land usage was tightly coupled with the natural environment. In keeping with the American example, the temperate climate and varied soils found in the north provided fertile ground for stable farming. Likewise, the harsher climate and extensive grasslands of the south best fit with a pastoral approach. Following this link all the way through, the natural environment of the pre-colonial United States had a great influence on the agrarian lifestyle of American settlers, and the agricultural approach of proximate populations established certain conditions of their socioecological environment. Finally, in line with the culture of honour hypothesis, this socioecological environment influenced the cultural phenotype of these populations, finalizing the connection between the natural environment and the value systems of the people who live there. In other words, the value system of a people can be tightly coupled with, and even derived from, their natural environment. These values are directly linked to what a thriving lifestyle in a given environment might look like. Within this, there lies the potential for reasonable and legitimate insights into a given way of life, grounded in a culture’s location-derived values.

At this point, I hope that the parallel with localized spiritual reasons has become clear. Indirect spiritual reasons, which are indicators and harbourers of a community’s value system, can provide insight into values which support the way of life that arises out of a given environment. While I do not think that this link exists solely in the domain of agricultural approach, I use this example to belabour the point that there is a rationale behind location-derived values. This rationale gives locally-grounded reasons a legitimacy in their entrance into the public sphere.

An added benefit of this potential for legitimacy is that it lessens the burden on the political process for guaranteeing responsible results. In his account, Rummens allows for the admission of arguments which may be considered irresponsible or malicious into the public sphere (such as religious arguments for racial discrimination or the oppression of women) on the

grounds that the deliberative procedure will filter out these unpopular perspectives (2010, 394–395). In my view, this puts a very high demand on the procedure and does not adequately protect against the sheer amount of influence on what constitutes “reasonableness” in the public. Having an element of legitimacy in the reasons themselves reduces the strain on the procedure in producing humane outcomes.

In this section, I introduced the concept of localized spiritual reasons, and characterized their difference from institutional religious reasons as the locally-grounded nature of their development and application. Then, I distinguished between the metaphysical concept of the authority attached to a reason and the legitimacy of a reason’s content. My aim in doing so was to affirm that even prior to arguing for the authority derived from the *context* of these reasons, the reasons themselves are credible, good-faith admittances into the public sphere, oftentimes with a traceable rationale and developmental path behind them. In the following section, I will present my argument against Rummens’ denial of authority arguments, and my thesis that localized spiritual reasons can be authoritative in the expertise they carry.

4. Authority of Localized Reasons

Rummens argues against the permissibility of admitting religious authority arguments into the public sphere because they curtail the process of deliberation amongst citizens. He defines religious authority arguments as those which “use a reference to religious sources of authority in an attempt to impose particular religious values or principles on the whole of society” (Rummens 2010, 389). Within the framework of a deliberative democracy, an individual entering the discursive process with nothing more than an appeal to authority is limiting the scope of the procedure and preemptively shutting down opportunities for meaningful exchange. An important component of this conceptualization is the aim of authority arguments to enact their divinity’s will onto the entirety of a state. Beyond cutting short the deliberative process from which political legitimacy is generated, authority arguments “aim to impose particular and thus nonuniversalizable religious obligations on the whole of society,” infringing on other citizens’ autonomy rights (394).

I agree with the rejection of this type of authority argument. Any argumentative reasons, religious or otherwise, which appeal to the authority of their source without any reflection regarding their rationale or motivation are simply falling prey to an authority bias. However,

Rummens' conception of authority in this article is not its only form. It is also possible, and indeed practical, for authority to arise out of expertise.

In a policy deliberation regarding any type of healthcare legislation, the testimony and perspective of healthcare workers and researchers is an imperative component of the process. Yet, if a doctor were to take the stand, and provide her perspective in the form, "I say that this is so, and I am a doctor, so it must be done," we would wonder at the absurdity of her presence in the discussion at all. Rather, when healthcare professionals provide their insights into related policy discourse, we place greater weight on their testimony due to their reasons' position within the broader context of the medical field, and from their expertise — developed through years of education, related research, and hands-on, practical experience. This is not to say that their perspectives should be blindly assumed without further investigation — this only returns us to the issue of appealing to authority. However, as their testimony flows through the broader democratic process of investigation and verification, from journalists to public servants to legislators, their reasons should be given greater weight than those with far less subject-matter knowledge and experience. Prioritizing and valuing expert knowledge is an important aspect of filtering out uninformed, or bad-faith, perspectives from the democratic process.

While expertise can be developed through professional and academic instruction, group testimony can also possess authority, grounded in the group members' shared lived experiences. For example, in a policy discussion regarding workplace sexual harassment, it would be misguided to base the ruling on the testimony of one individual woman, who may confirm or utterly deny its existence. If instead, however, the hearing included the group testimony of a sufficient number of women, a form of knowledge would arise out of the mosaic of their experiences. This knowledge would be grounded by the shared situation, or context, that the members' perspectives exist within. It would be considered erroneous to push forward any sort of policy without adequate consultation of the identity groups which would be most impacted by its enactment. This is precisely due to the expertise that these collectives contain regarding the policy's impacts and consequences, grounded in their unique experience of living through them.

It is here where Rummens' conception of authority arguments begins to falter. It simply does not adequately capture the different types of authority which may be leveraged within the political process. Localized spiritual reasons contain this authority-from-expertise, developed from both sources detailed in the above examples. They contain the expertise which grows out of

hands-on, rigorous education, based on their members' historic and scientific knowledge of the location they were developed on. And, they contain group expertise grounded in the unique experience, and perspective, of generations of life lived in a particular location. Where Rummens rejects institutional religious reasons which aim to (inappropriately) appeal to authority to enact universal policy, I argue that localized spiritual reasons are authoritative in their locally-grounded expertise. This is not to say that they should be assumed without further discourse, but they should be given greater *weight* in a deliberation, in the same way that the doctor's insights, or the women's group testimony, would.

In *Fire Burning*, localized spiritual reasons justifying cultural and prescribed burns as a forest management process carry greater weight in policy discussions because they contain expert knowledge of local ecosystems. This knowledge has been empirically developed through Indigenous peoples' existence on, and stewardship of, their land since time immemorial. Many Indigenous "Elders, Fire Keepers, and Fire Knowledge Holders have expertise in cultural burning practices that include having specific teachings about fuel conditions, weather, fire behaviour, and burning techniques" (Christianson et al. 2024, 14). For example, members of the Nlaka'pamux and Coldwater First Nations recognize the process as a lifestyle, rather than a one-off event, with expertise regarding the specific fire cycles tailored to each ecosystem: grasslands were burned every one to two years, seven to 15 years was required for ponderosa pine ecosystems, and there were 60 to 100 years per burn for ecosystems with lodgepole pine (7). A number of Indigenous cultures hold "good fire" as one of the four sacred elements on Earth, through which both people and the spaces around them are purified (13).

Rummens rejects the admittance of authority arguments into the public sphere as they end discussion under a deliberative democracy. However, in *Fire Burning*, the expertise contained in localized spiritual reasons not only doesn't end policy discussion, but is also an invaluable source of knowledge which has guided British Columbian policy to a more sustainable and effective outcome. These sorts of reasons provide unique insights when entered into the public sphere and shape policy to be more grounded in the local environment it is being practiced within. At the same time, these reasons do not impede the deliberative process as the authority of their source is not blindly assumed. Rather, that authority is observed in the form of respect for the domain expertise contained by spiritual practitioners, grounded in their longstanding existence on the land the political process is occurring on.

While this expertise is perhaps illustrated most clearly in the example of direct spiritual reasons as outlined in *Fire Burning*, I believe a level of expertise can also be found in indirect reasons. In *Tsawalk: A Nuu-chah-nulth Worldview*, scholar and hereditary chief Umeek, Richard Atleo, presents an ontology of both physical and metaphysical reality founded in Nuu-chah-nulth origin stories and characterized by the proposition of Tsawalk, that everything is one. As opposed to discarding localized spiritualities as a lower form of reasoning, “the theory of Tsawalk not only begins with these “tales,” or origin stories, but also depends on these “tales” both as the foundation of knowledge about the state of existence and as a guide for its interpretation” (Atleo 2004, xi). Importantly, Tsawalk does not compartmentalize the realms of reason and spirit. Rather, it “assumes a spiritual primacy to existence” where the physical world is a “manifestation or creation ... of its spiritual Creator,” and where the highest form of consciousness occurs in “the realm of creation’s spiritual source” (xvi). Within this framework, Atleo suggests that the Western conception of reason and knowledge acquisition is built upon the metaphysical assumption that primary experience, and truth, is physical or empirical. This claim to the uniqueness of knowledge contained in spiritual myth can be paralleled with Habermas’s claim that institutional religions are a possible medium for unique truths (2006, 10). However, while Habermas limits the potential knowledge contained in religious reasons to specialized insights into moral intuitions, Atleo suggests that spiritual myths are capable of containing truths about existence which lie beyond empirical experience.

Atleo argues that as human reason may not be the sole source of knowledge, “faith and spirit” may play an important role in knowledge acquisition (Atleo 2004, xii). Umeek means this literally, and proposes Tsawalk as a theoretical alternative — and potential addition — to the sort of knowledge acquisition pursued by Western science with the aim of achieving a more complete picture of the universe. I believe that this framework is beneficial for understanding the sorts of reasons entered into the political process, even within a secular, liberal state. Namely, this “spirit” already seems to exist within our politics, in the form of the *indirect* religious reasons entered into the public sphere.

As I have been claiming thus far, there is a unique expertise contained within spiritualities developed locally, both within the empirical knowledge they harbour and within the locally-developed values they communicate. Under this lens, *Corrections* can be understood as a leveraging of the authority of a local spirit (or value system). To go even further, prior to the

integration of Indigenous spiritual knowledge into *Corrections*, a spirit already existed within carceral policy in Canada. However, this was an “imported” spirit, developed away from the lands they were enacted on, and brought into the House of Commons under the guise of a “rational” secular politics. This is not to say that value systems or policy frameworks cannot be brought across state lines. Rather, it seems to me to be a willful ignorance to deny the existence of an imported, institutionally religious spirit which lies as the foundation of all secular policy — at least in the context of colonial states — and to treat this spirit as authoritative to the point of permanence. Given the groundedness of knowledge, values, ways of life, and particular worldviews with the environment and land they exist on, there is an expertise to be consulted in the peoples who have lived on those lands for generations, or even since time immemorial.

In this section, I presented my argument for the unique authority found in localized spiritual reasons. Rummens’ conception of authority only accounts for the sort found in an authority bias, and does not consider the more tempered form of authority that arises out of expertise. This expertise can be developed in a number of ways, including through empirical development, and through unique lived experiences within a given situation. Localized spiritual reasons contain both of these. Namely, direct spiritual reasons give access to the invaluable sorts of empirical knowledge that has been developed about a location, through living on and understanding that environment over generations. Indirect spiritual reasons provide insight into the “spirit” which arises out of living in a given environment and setting. Both of these sorts of reasons should not be assumed without question in their entrance into political discourse. However, I argue that they should be treated as the testimony of the doctor, or of the group of women — as unique, rigorous, and valuable additions to the public sphere, given a greater weight due to the expertise grounded in their position.

5. Outstanding Considerations and Concluding Remarks

Up to this point I have argued for the inclusion of authoritative localized spiritual reasons into the public sphere based on the importance of their expertise. However, I view this discussion as

opening the door to a number of potential future considerations and concerns. I will discuss the two which I believe to be most fruitful for further inquiry here.

Firstly, the discussion in this paper is grounded in my perspective that different types, sources, or contents of religious reasons lead to differing acceptability intuitions. I have repeatedly cited the examples of same-sex marriage and *Fire Buring* to illustrate my contrasting intuitions when considering authority arguments grounded in institutional religions versus localized spiritualities. However, if this discussion leads in the direction of looking at *particular* religious or spiritual reasons for their acceptability, it raises the question of just who or what would adjudicate what reasons qualify. Certain reasons within any given religion could be cherry-picked, or excluded, on a phony call for “acceptability” from a malicious judge. Drilling down into particular reasons leaves open the possibility of exploiting the process by which those particulars are evaluated by nefarious actors.

One check present in my discussion is that while I have been considering types of reasons, my argument is still dealing with classes as a whole, rather than a set of acceptable particulars. Namely, it is the characteristics of a certain class of reasons that gives them a level of authority, rather than a combined authority derived from particular reasons themselves. However, this allowance still requires a just and rigorous process for those classes to be situated within, constructed in part by the presence of a free press, an educated populace, and available resources for ease of engagement in public debate.

Secondly, Habermas states that only secular reasons should be permitted into the formal sphere of parliament, legislation, and administration (2006, 9). The question then remains as to whether the legitimacy and authority contained in localized spiritual reasons is sufficient for their promotion from the informal to the formal public sphere. Furthermore, if specifically Indigenous spiritual reasons were to be accepted into the formal public sphere, there is question as to whether this would be accomplished on an epistemic axis, or on the axis of decolonial justice.

One might argue that the weight of localized spiritual reasons does not give them unique admittance into formal public spaces over reasons from institutional religions. The content of localized spiritual reasons still seem to be translatable into secular vernacular, and it may be unconvincing that their expertise is enough to enter them into the formal public sphere in their metaphysical form. Yet, certain formal spaces, such as committee hearings or oral evidence sessions, allow for testimony from the public, including from related affected groups and subject

matter experts. In this way, it seems to me that the empirical nature of the spiritual reasons included in *Fire Burning* can be best compared with the testimony of the doctor. The direct, localized spiritual reasons provided in these sorts of cases seem to carry enough rigour to (at the minimum) have an argument for being included in these sorts of spaces without having to be translated into secular reasons.

The more ambitious concern, then, is the admittance of localized spiritual reasons into a formal political sphere totally distanced from the act of testimony. I am unsure if their authority, as I have argued for it, is sufficient for overriding the liberal separation of religion — or spirituality — and formal politics. If any case were to be made for this move, it may instead fall under the domain of reparative justice. The exclusion of specifically Indigenous spirituality in the governance of colonial states was not some unfortunate circumstance, but was the deliberate consequence of legislation, over-policing, and violence. A decolonial argument could be made for the allowance of Indigenous spiritual reasons into the formal public sphere as a correction of past, and current, exclusionary measures, and as an act of reconciliation. However, in my view, this is of lower priority than the total return to Indigenous peoples' sovereign governance over their own lands, entirely outside of the colonial system.

The topic of this paper arose out of a friction I encountered when considering my conflicting intuitions regarding the authoritative power of reasons from institutional religions versus those from more localized spiritualities. I have argued that there is an epistemic difference in these classes of reasons, based on their application on the land from which they were derived. While it is my intention for this argument to apply to all sorts of localized spiritualities, Indigenous or otherwise, it would be foolish to pretend that the drivers of my thought process were not the reconciliatory efforts to re-integrate Indigenous knowledge into the colonial political system under which I have spent the entirety of my life. As such, much of my argument relies on examples of Indigenous spirituality — something that I, ironically, have no authority on. It is under this context that I also wish to refrain from grounding my argument in some romanticized, holistic view of the world from which authority somehow springs. I also wish to refrain from defining secularism as a concept totally introduced to the Americas through Western colonization. While secularism is often employed as one tool in the colonial toolbox, some Indigenous peoples were engaging in (and still engage in) a separation of spirituality and politics prior to the colonization of the Americas (Carr 2022). On the other hand, the specifically

Nuu-chah-nulth worldview as outlined by Atleo uses “spirituality” not to refer to some analog of institutional religion, but rather as an understanding where the land, plants, animals, and people all have their own spirit, integrity, and substance which must be respected (2004).

It is out of respect for the sheer diversity of thought exemplified by Indigenous nations that my discussion has focused on the epistemic authority of localized spiritual reasons. It seems to me to be an undervaluation of the contents of these reasons to only desire to platform them from the perspective of reparative justice, or from some romanticized and bastardized standpoint of the Indigenous “way of life.” The *reasons themselves* carry an incredible amount of empirical weight, and their sources deserve to be treated with the same respect and scrutiny that we would inflict on any other expert reason entered into the public sphere.

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